and mine had been delayed. I drifted back to sleep but a little later woke up again and asked a doctor if the ordeal was finally over. To my surprise I was told that this time they had had to wake me because of an unexpected discovery. They had spotted a ruptured tendon in my right biceps and needed my consent to fix it while they did the shoulder surgery. I agreed, but asked them to make sure I recovered in time for the West Indies series! In fact, as soon as I'd got back to my room from the operating theatre, I cried and cried because I thought I was going to miss the West Indies series, which I was very eager to play in.

Within five weeks of the double surgery I picked up a cricket bat and even played a few shots to tennis balls. My family and friends Atul Ranade and Jagdish Chavan were with me throughout the recovery and I got them to bowl at me from 18 yards to get used to the extra pace that I was likely to encounter in the West Indies. In hindsight I concede that I probably pushed myself too hard. When my physio and doctors asked me to play thirty balls a day, I played sixty.

After practising to short-pitched bowling for four days, I asked one of my friends to bowl at me from the full 22 yards, to get used to swing and seam movement. All was fine until I felt a sudden jerk. I immediately stopped and one look was enough to frighten me. My biceps was hanging like a hammock and my first impression was that I had ruptured it again. I was desperate to speak to John Gloster and report what had happened, but John was then in the West Indies with the team and, because of the time difference, I had to wait eight or nine hours before I was able to speak to him. Those hours were a real nightmare. John advised complete rest for the next few days. The incident had really shaken me up. A week later I went to Chennai and met up with our trainer, Ramji Srinivasan. I wanted to work on my physical fitness, even if I couldn't bat. I trained hard for a week but it was to no avail. I had lost confidence completely and decided not to go to the West Indies for the June 2006 Test series.

Led by Rahul Dravid, who had replaced Sourav Ganguly as captain, the team played outstandingly well. Rahul batted brilliantly in truly trying conditions and we won the four-Test series 1–0. It was our first series win in the Caribbean for thirty-five years – and I was frustrated at missing every single bit of the action. I called my team-mates after the victory and congratulated them on a fantastic series win.